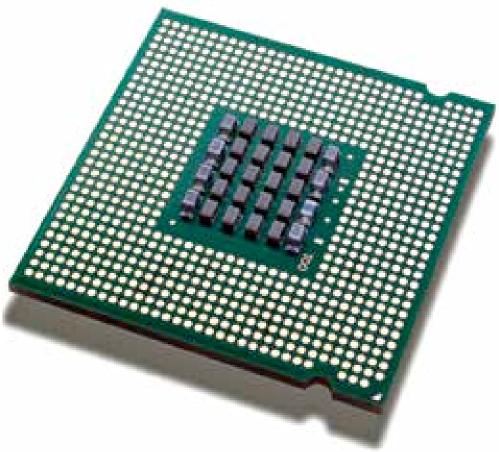

ment in battery life over every other competing CPU is staggering. If you want a portable device, you wouldn't want any other CPU in your laptop. An i7 is simply an indulgence. It's definitely nice to have one, but you'll rarely need anything more than an i5 for most of your needs. Also remember, when it comes to gaming, an i5 + GPU combo is way better than just an i7 CPU.

If you're on a tight budget, get a Celeron powered device. For something a bit more powerful, get a laptop that's powered by an i3 CPU. If you need a good all-rounder, get a device with an i5 and an NVIDIA GPU. Obviously, if your budget permits it, an i7 and a more powerful NVIDIA GPU will ensure that you're sorted for at least two years of computing pleasure.

AMD: If you're willing to sacrifice some amount of CPU power and battery power for better graphics performance, then AMD's APUs were created for you. You'll identify these CPUs by the "A" before their model number (AMD A6, for example).

For those not in the know, an APU is essentially an AMD GPU that's been mated with an AMD CPU. In effect, what you get is a hybrid CPU-GPU combo that offers you something less than the best of both worlds. Take the case of the A10 APU. When pitted against an i5 (in the same price bracket), it offers you the computational power of a Celeron M and GPU power that's about 30% below what you'd get from an NVIDIA 700M. That said, the combination works quite well, especially in GPU-intensive applications, but there are very few other scenarios where you'd appreciate the APU.

Another main drawback of the APU is the tremendous loss in battery life, which is about half of what you'd get with an i5, and easily seven times lower than what you'd get from a Celeron. AMD's E1, which is its low-end APU, is a bad choice for budget laptops however and even though the graphics option (on paper) is better than that on the competing Celeron, no amount of graphical power can compensate for the loss in processing power.

RAM

Apart from the processor, the cheapest and best way to quickly boost a computer's performance is by beefing up its system memory or RAM. Most pre-configured laptops these days offer at least 2 GB of RAM – it's pretty much the standard. We recommend you to upgrade system memory or RAM from the get-go. Don't wait to do so until your system starts getting sluggish a year down the line. If you're having your laptop built to order at a vendor's website, don't hesitate to add extra RAM then and there. If you're buying laptops off the counter at an electronics store, ask for a range that has more than 2 GB of pre-installed RAM. Upgrading to 3 GB or 4 GB may seem like overkill initially, but if you want to hang on to the laptop for a while, that extra memory will be money well spent and keep your system motoring along longer.

For a budget-conscious customer, stick with at least 2 GB of RAM on your laptop – any lower and we're talking about netbooks, not laptops. For those desiring an all-purpose laptop, a minimum of 4 GB of RAM should be good enough for handling multimedia, entertainment and casual gaming, apart from every-day tasks.

In case of upgrading your laptop's RAM, make sure you double-check the maximum clock timings supported by your laptop's RAM. While buying two sticks instead of one, don't buy RAM from different manufacturers. Stick with only one manufacturer to save a good amount of troubleshooting time. Ideally, buy two identical RAM sticks that share the same manufacturer, clock setting, capacity, etc.

Hard drive

If there's one thing to be glad about personal computing and technology in general today is that storage costs have considerably dropped. Cost per GB is the best it has ever been and it's expected to go down even further in the coming months. This is good news for budget-conscious laptop buyers because it eases their woes a bit. But having said that, opting for a fatter, faster hard drive is still going to eat into your budget and be more expensive than buying a slower hard drive with less space. Settle for a 320GB or 500GB hard drive with a 5,400rpm spin speed – which is still the de facto on most budget notebooks – instead of lusting for that 750GB or 1TB drive spinning at 7,200rpm, unless you really require it.

Don't even think about SSDs. They're unfortunately still out of range for all budget and most all-purpose laptops even today. SSD prices, too, are witnessing significant price drops but they are still